Storyboard — AI-Assisted Course Design Workflow (Automation Only)

Scope note: This storyboard covers the touchpoints of the n8n automation itself — what a requester, reviewer, or SME actually sees at each stage, from training request to approved brief. It does not cover the Storyline course (see `storyboard-prototype.md` for that).

Touchpoint 1 — Training Request Form

Who sees this: Anyone requesting a new course (a manager, SME, or L&D colleague).

What they see: A form with the fields defined in the blueprint (Requester name, email, department, topic, business problem, audience, audience size, delivery format, deadline, source material, SME contact, compliance flag, tone).

On submission: A simple confirmation message: "Thanks — your request has been logged. You'll hear back once the draft brief is ready for review."

Logic behind it: Form Trigger node fires → all fields pass into the workflow as one data object → immediately logged as a new row in the Google Sheet with status `New`.

Access & distribution note: The form itself needs no login to submit — n8n's Form Trigger generates a public URL the moment the workflow is activated. "Access" in practice means *distribution*, not permissions: the link gets shared wherever requesters already look (a Slack/Teams channel, an intranet page, onboarding material), not gated inside n8n. For a production version, restricting who can submit would mean either using a Google Form (which can require an organizational Google login) or placing the link behind an already-authenticated internal portal — noted here as a scope limitation, not solved in this prototype.

Owner notification: Since submitting the form is what starts the workflow, and n8n doesn't notify the workflow owner by default, a **Send Email** node fires immediately after the Form Trigger — to the workflow owner, not the requester — with the key fields (topic, requester, department, deadline) in the body. This is what keeps the person who built the workflow in the loop the moment a request comes in, rather than having to check the Executions tab manually.

Touchpoint 2 — (No visible screen) AI Drafting

Who sees this: No one — this stage is invisible to the requester and reviewer.

What happens: The request fields are assembled into the objectives/outline prompt (Template A + B from the blueprint), sent to the AI model, and the response is captured.

Why it's worth storyboarding anyway: Even invisible stages are worth documenting, because this is where things can silently go wrong (empty response, malformed output) — see the fallback behavior in Touchpoint 6.

Touchpoint 3 — Draft Brief Document

Who sees this: The SME/reviewer, via a link in their review email (Touchpoint 4).

What they see: A Google Doc titled something like "Course Brief — [Topic] — Draft," containing the AI-generated learning objectives and course outline, formatted for readability (headers, numbered objectives).

Logic behind it: Google Docs "Create Document" node writes the formatted brief; the Doc's URL is captured and passed forward to the email step.

Touchpoint 4 — Review Email

Who sees this: The designated SME/reviewer.

What they see:

> Subject: Review needed — Course Brief: [Topic]
>
> Body: "A draft brief is ready for your review. Please check the objectives and outline below (also linked as a Google Doc), then submit your decision."
>
> Embedded form fields (via Send-and-Wait custom form):
>
> - Decision: Approve / Revise / Reject
> - Comments/Feedback (free text, required if Revise or Reject)

Interaction: Reviewer reads the brief (in the email body and/or the linked Doc), selects a decision, optionally adds feedback, and submits.

Logic behind it: Send Email node, operation "Send and Wait for a Response," Custom Form type. This is the human approval gate — the workflow pauses here until the form is submitted or the wait-time limit is reached.

Touchpoint 5 — Outcome: Approve

Who sees this: The original requester.

What they see:

> Subject: Your course brief is approved
>
> Body: “Good news — the brief for [Topic] has been approved and is ready to move into course development.”

Logic behind it: IF node routes here on Decision = Approve → Google Sheets row updated to status `Approved` → Google Doc updated/finalized → notification email sent to requester.

Touchpoint 6 — Outcome: Revise (loop)

Who sees this: The SME/reviewer again, after a short delay.

What they see: A second review email, identical in structure to Touchpoint 4, but the brief has been updated based on their feedback: “Here’s the revised brief based on your feedback. Please review again.”

Logic behind it: IF node routes here on Decision = Revise → feedback + original draft combined into a refine prompt → sent back to the AI model → Doc updated → back to Touchpoint 4. A revision counter caps this at 3 rounds before forcing an Approve-path escalation with a flag for manual follow-up, so the loop can’t run indefinitely.

Touchpoint 7 — Outcome: Reject

Who sees this: The original requester.

What they see:

> Subject: Your course request needs a follow-up conversation
>
> Body: “The brief for [Topic] wasn’t approved as submitted. Reason: [reviewer’s feedback]. Let’s discuss next steps.”

Logic behind it: IF node routes here on Decision = Reject → Sheet status updated to `Rejected`, with the reviewer's reason logged → requester notified → workflow ends (no further automation; this becomes a human conversation).

Touchpoint 8 — (Invisible) Error/Fallback Handling

Who sees this: An admin/workflow owner only, not the requester or reviewer.

What happens: If the AI call fails, times out, or returns a suspiciously short response, an Error Trigger workflow catches it, logs status `Failed` in the Sheet, and emails an admin alert with the raw error — so a broken draft never reaches the SME, and the failure doesn't go unnoticed.

Why this is worth showing on its own

Storyboarding the automation separately makes a point worth stating outright in an interview: the workflow isn't just plumbing between an API and a spreadsheet — every stage has a real human on the other end of it (a requester waiting for a decision, an SME being asked to make a judgment call), and the design accounts for what each of them actually experiences, including when something goes wrong.